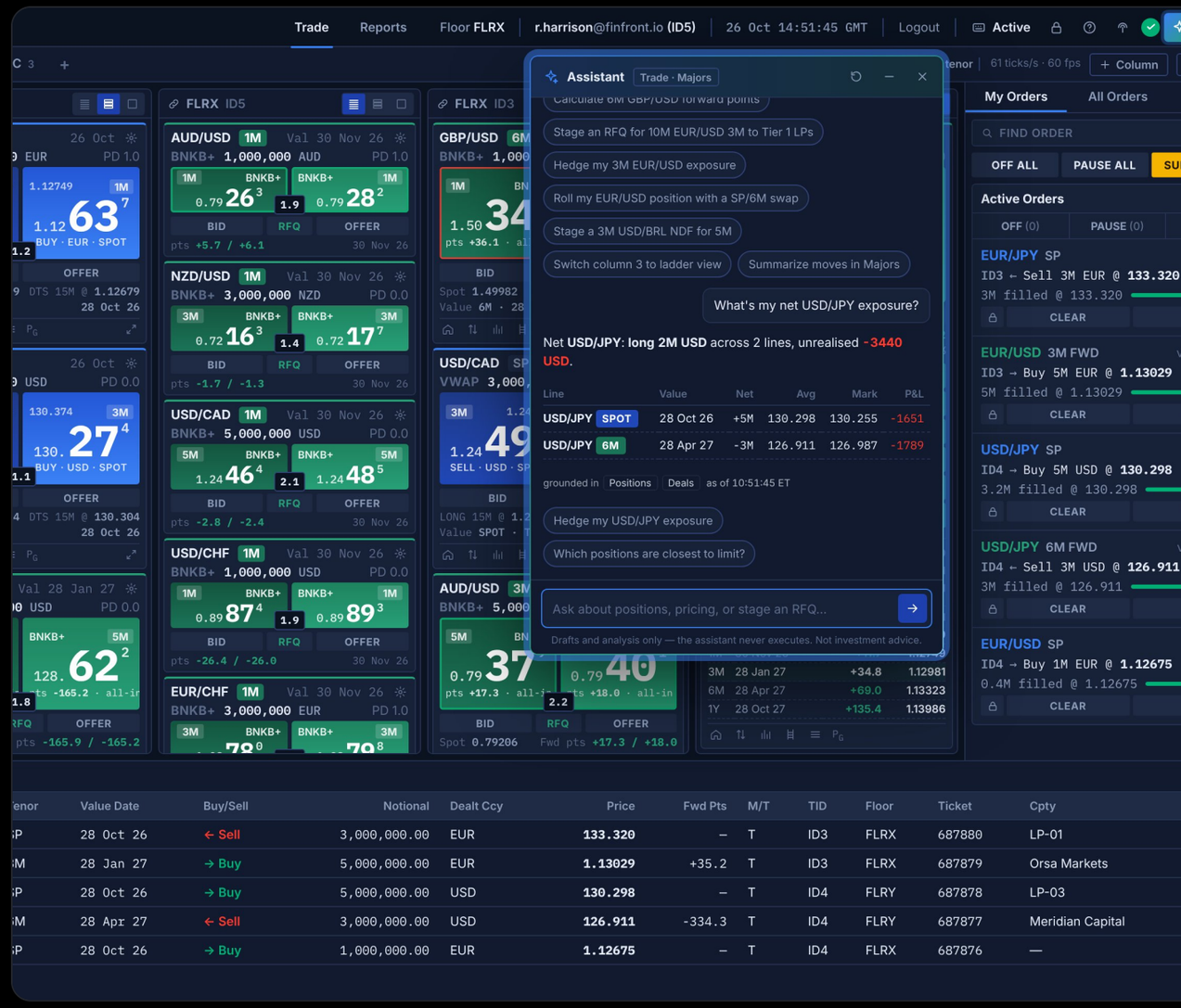
FINFRONT SDK ASSISTANT

A CASE STUDY IN AI-NATIVE UX

Designing an AI assistant traders can trust.

Seven design decisions from a desk assistant that **drafts, cites, and waits** — never blocks a price, never sends an order.



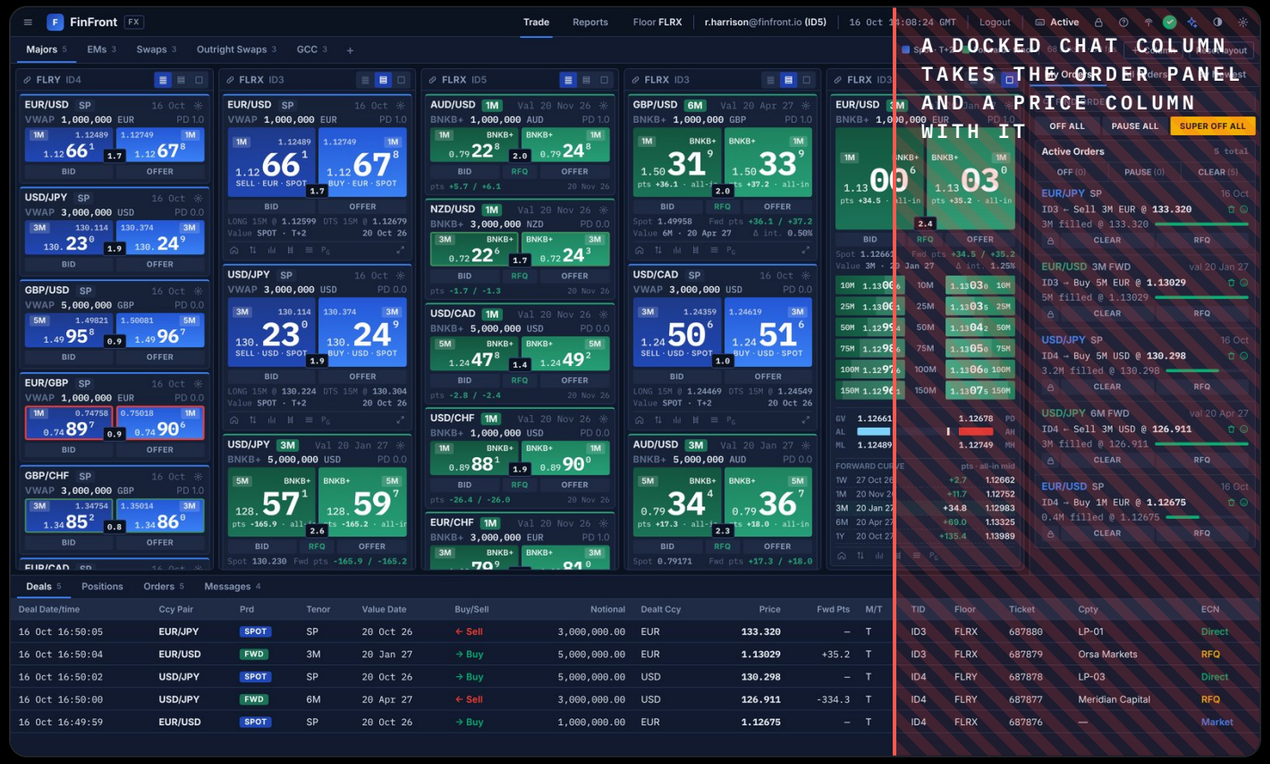
RICK HOLLANDSWORTH · PRINCIPAL PRODUCT DESIGNER

rick.hollandsworth@outlook.com · (201) 404-5031

OCTOBER 2026

On a trading desk, an assistant that hides prices or acts alone is a liability.

Most AI assistants are designed for a blank page. A trader's screen is already full, and every number on it is live. The assistant has to earn its place **without covering a price or touching an order.**



The desk doesn't want a chatbot.

It wants a second pair of eyes that answers in its own numbers — and leaves the buttons alone.

So the brief had five parts.

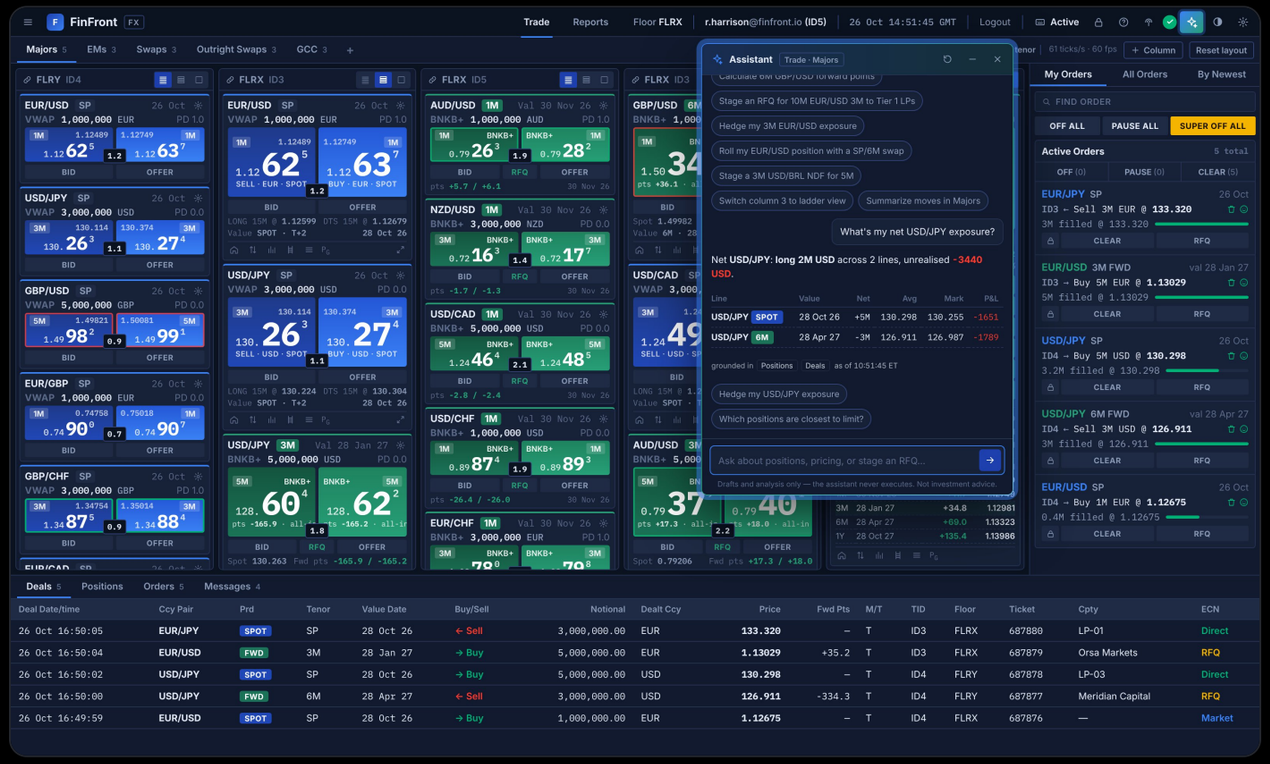
Never block the data. Never execute. Show every source. Only interrupt when there's something new. Stop when asked.

READ THIS FIRST

FinFront is a self-directed prototype with synthetic data. There are no usage numbers here — this is a study of design decisions, not results.

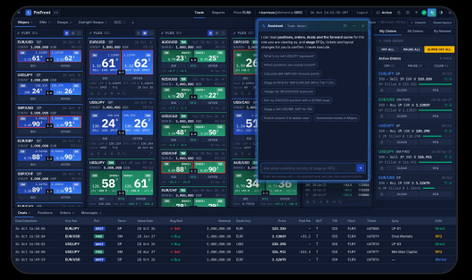
Never block the data.

The assistant is a **floating panel**, not a docked column. Drag it over whatever you aren't watching, minimise it to a title bar, or close it. The ladder underneath never loses a column.





PARKED LEFT



DEFAULT · BY THE ORDERS

01 Drag it by the title bar — anywhere on the screen.

02 Minimise to one row; close and reopen with one key.

03 It remembers where you left it, per user.

04 Nothing underneath reflows. No column ever leaves.

Stage, never execute.

Ask for an RFQ and the assistant **drafts** one — pair, amount, tenor, Tier-1 LPs, indicative points — as a staged card. **Open RFQ** loads the desk's own ticket, pre-filled. SEND stays a human button.

1 · STAGED CARD

only.

✦ STAGED · FORWARD RFQ

Pair	EUR/USD
Amount	10,000,000 EUR
Tenor · value	3M · 28 Jan 27
Indicative	1.12968 / 1.12988
LPs	3 × Tier 1
Fwd pts	+34.5 / +35.2

Open RFQ | Discard

Opens the RFQ pre-filled; you press SEND RFQ and choose the quote.

grounded in Curve | LP roster as of 10:51:59 ET

ⓘ Indicative: priced off the mid curve and deposit rates, not LP quotes. Firm prices come back on the ticket.

What's my net USD/JPY exposure?

Which positions are closest to limit?

Ask about positions, pricing, or stage an RFQ →

OPEN RFQ

2 · THE DESK'S TICKET, PRE-FILLED

FORWARD New FX transaction ticket RFQ-20261026-0422

Spot | Forward | Swap | NDF

1 · TRANSACTION DETAILS — Single leg · priced on forward points

CURRENCY PAIR: EUR/USD

DIRECTION: Two-way | Buy EUR | Sell EUR

LPs quote both sides; you hit or lift.

AMOUNT: 10,000,000 EUR | EUR · base | USD · terms

≈ 11,262,100 USD at spot mid

TENOR: 3M | 01/28/2027

Value 27 Jan 27 · 3M from spot 28 Oct 26

SPOT REFERENCE	INDICATIVE FWD PTS	INDICATIVE ALL-IN	NOTIONAL (BASE)	DIRECTION
1.12613 / 1.12629	+34.5 / +35.2	1.12958 / 1.12981	10M EUR	Two-way

2 · LIQUIDITY PROVIDERS IN COMPETITION — Select all | Tier 1 only | Clear

☑ Northbank	Tier 1	☑ Meridian Capital	Tier 1	☑ Castell & Rowe	Tier 1
☐ Orsa Markets	Tier 2	☐ Helvetic Trading	Tier 2	☐ Kestrel Liquidity	NBLP

→ SEND RFQ · 3 LPs — Assistant-drafted request. Review LPs and amount, then SEND.

THE TRADER'S BUTTON — UNTOUCHED

Panel footer, every screen: “the assistant never executes.”

Show your sources.

Answers come back as **numbers in a table**, computed from the desk's live state — and each one says what it read, **and when**.

01 **A table, not a paragraph**

The desk's own units — spot, rates, day fraction — so nothing has to be re-read.

02 **“grounded in” + “as of”**

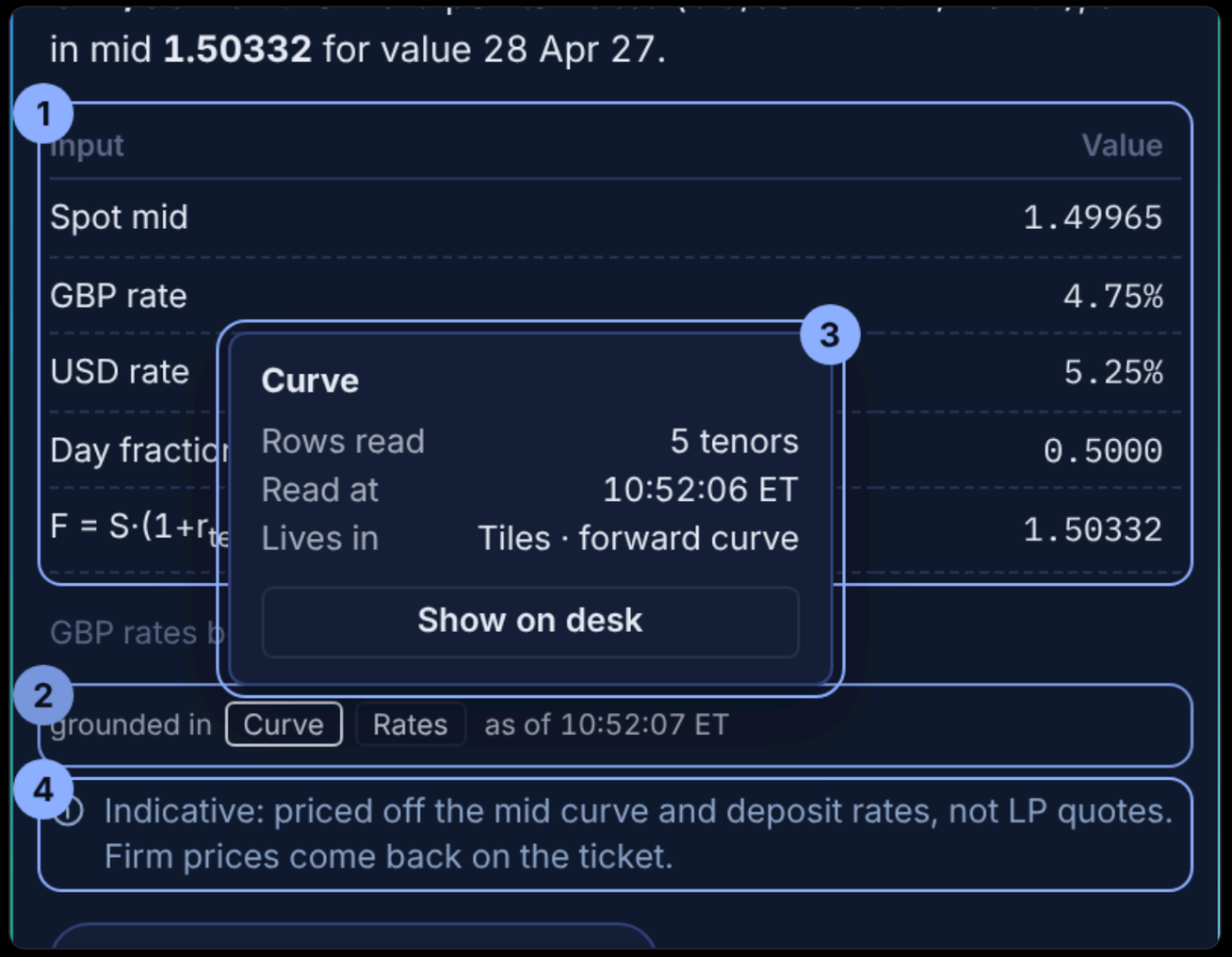
Every answer names each source it read and the time it read them: `as of 10:52:07 ET`.

03 **Preview any source**

Hover a chip for rows read, read time and where it lives, with **Show on desk**. Table rows keep their focus link.

04 **One line of assumptions**

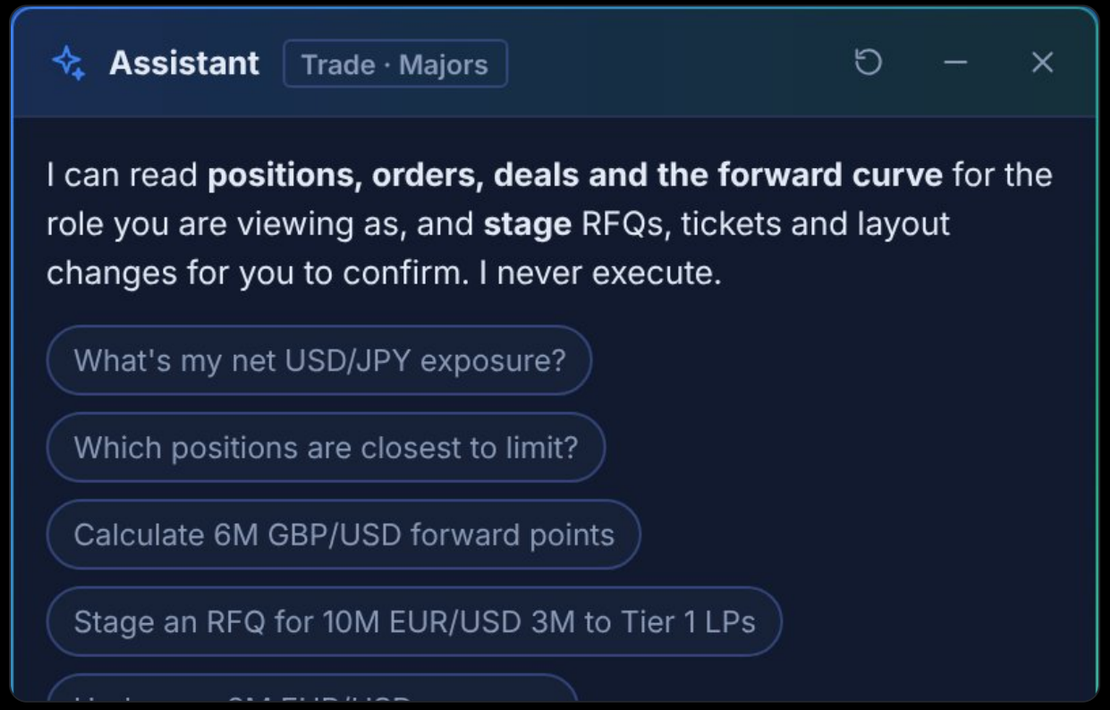
Stale, partial or estimated inputs get one muted info line — never amber, which means staged.



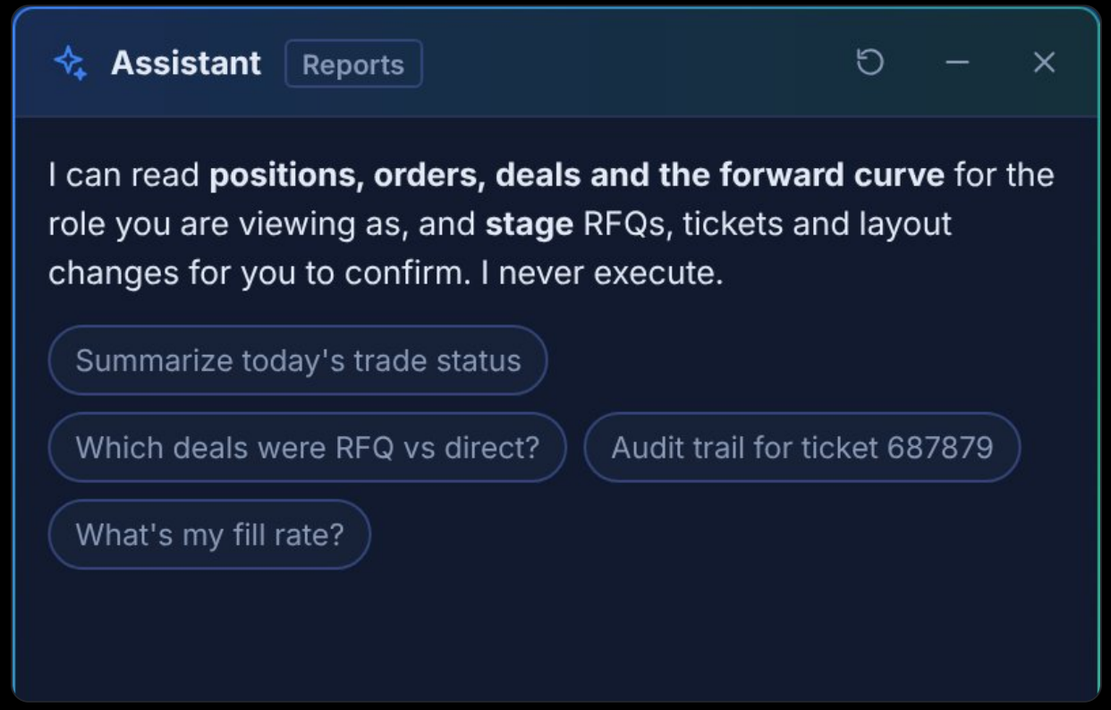
Suggest what fits the screen.

The prompt chips aren't a menu — they follow the **context chip** in the panel header. **Trade · Majors** offers hedges, rolls and RFQs for the pairs on screen; **Reports** offers audit trails and fill rates. After every answer, 1–3 follow-ups suggest the next step.

TRADE · MAJORS



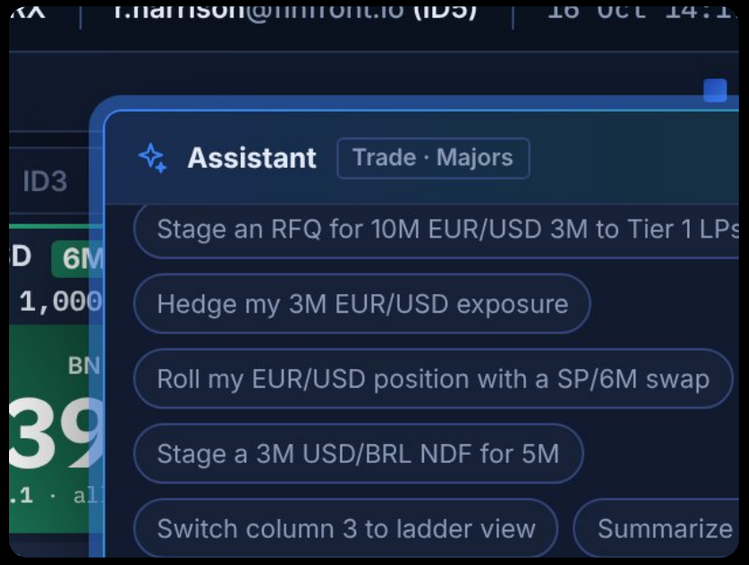
REPORTS



Get noticed only when it matters.

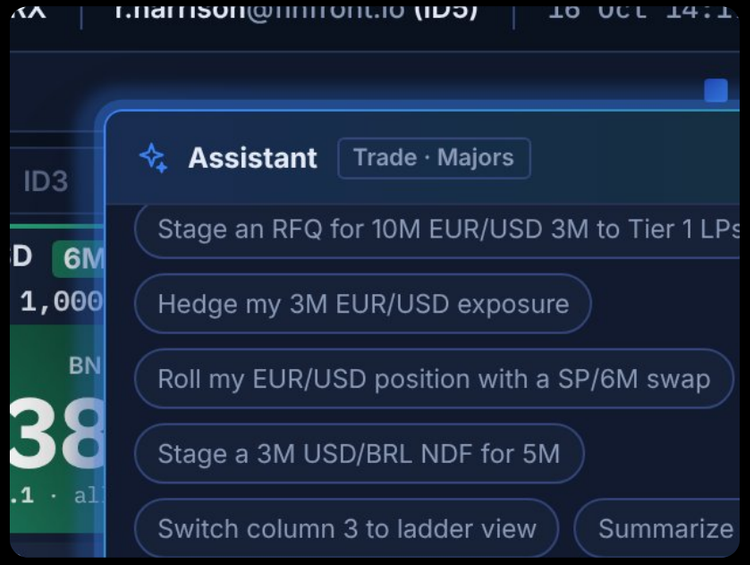
The blue-to-green border **beats** twice on open and once when a reply lands — only if you aren't already looking. Closed, one amber dot on the toolbar holds the unread reply. There is no idle animation.

IDLE · READING



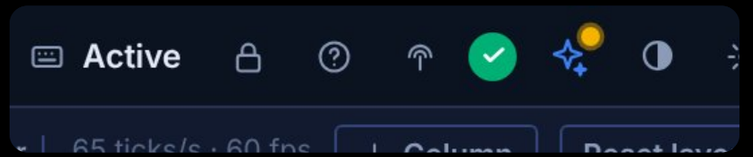
A gradient hairline and a soft halo. Nothing moves while you read.

REPLY LANDS · ONE BEAT



One ring, 0 → 26 px as it fades, 1.2 s, once. Skipped entirely if the panel has focus or the cursor.

CLOSED · REPLY WAITING

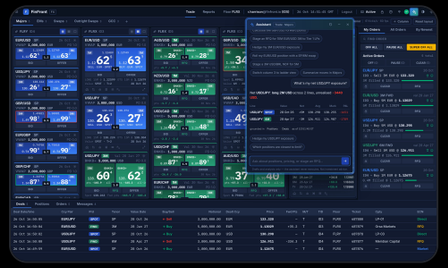


One static amber dot on the assistant button. Open it and the reply is already there.

FinFront SDK is a self-directed prototype built for portfolio demonstration — not a licensed product. All data shown is synthetic.

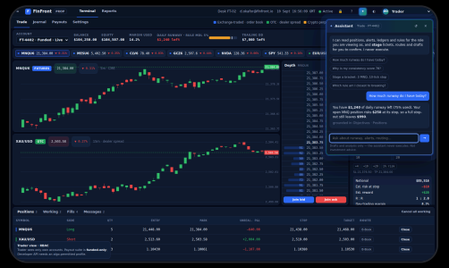
One pattern, five desks.

FX, Prop, RIA, CRE and Commodities share one assistant: same panel, same header and context chip, same first message, same promise. Only what it can **read** and **stage** changes with the desk and your role.



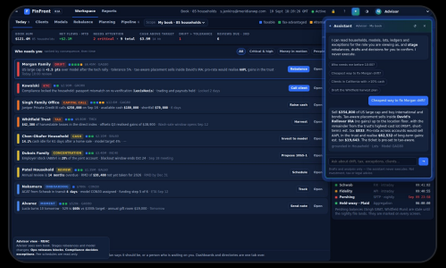
FX TERMINAL

Trade · Majors



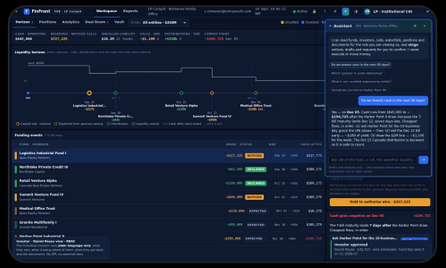
PROP DESK

Trade · FT-4402



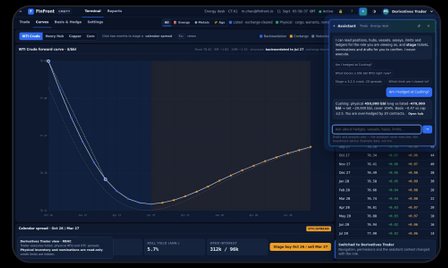
RIA WORKSPACE

Advisor · My book



CRE · LP COCKPIT

CIO · Romanov Family Office



COMMODITIES

Trade · Energy desk

SAME OPENING LINE

“I can read … for the role you are viewing as, and stage … for you to confirm. I never execute.”

SAME SCOPE RULE

The role chip in the top bar decides what the assistant can see. Switch roles and its context, chips and permissions switch with it.

SAME ENGINE

One shared guardrails layer runs on all five: sources, read time, steps, Stop and the failure state behave identically, in both themes.

FinFront SDK is a self-directed prototype built for portfolio demonstration — not a licensed product. All data shown is synthetic.

Stay interruptible.

While it works, the assistant says **what it is reading**, in plain steps. Send becomes **Stop** in the same place, and Esc stops too. If a source fails or takes longer than 8 seconds, it **says so** and offers a way forward.

WORKING · STEPS + SKELETON



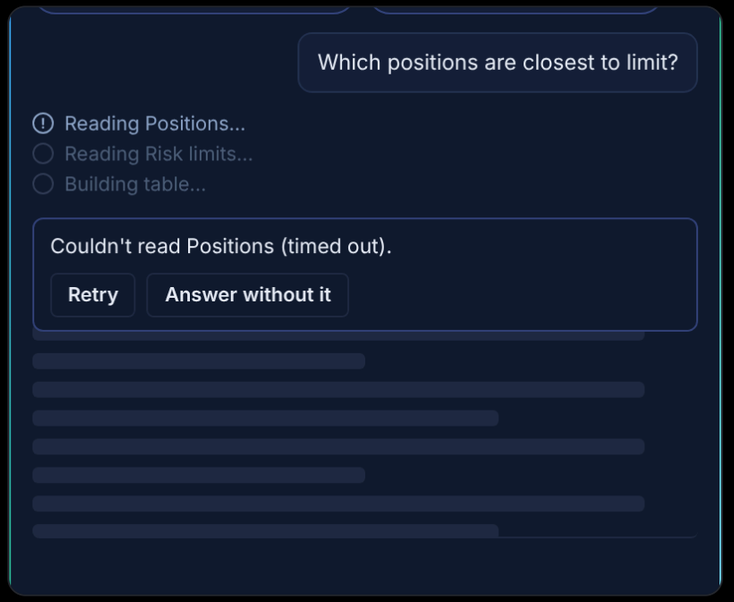
Each step names a real read and ticks when done. The skeleton holds the final height, so nothing moves.

STOPPED · PARTIAL ANSWER KEPT



Stop sits where Send was, and Esc works too. What already landed stays, labelled **Stopped**.

FAILED READ · RETRY OR ANSWER WITHOUT

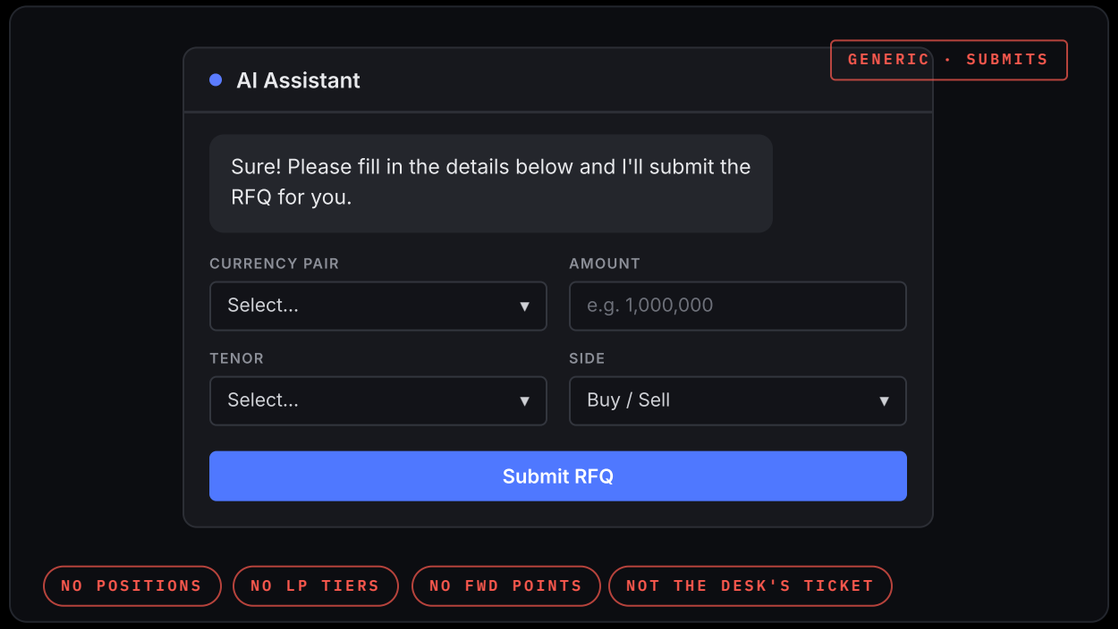


"Couldn't read Positions (timed out)." Retry, or answer without it — which adds an assumptions line.

Where the AI got it wrong.

Asked to “stage an RFQ”, Claude's first pass produced a **generic chat form**: pair, amount, submit. No live positions, no LP tiers, no forward points. The fix wasn't a prompt tweak; it was a rule: **read the live book, draft the desk's own ticket, leave SEND to the trader.**

FIRST DRAFT · REJECTED



Correct, and useless: it knew nothing the desk already knew.

REDIRECTED · SHIPPED



Reads the curve and LP roster, drafts the card, cites both, hands off to the real ticket.

Four principles for an assistant on a live screen.

01

Never block the data.

Float, drag, minimise, dismiss. The work underneath is the product; the assistant is a guest on it.

02

Stage, never execute.

Draft into the real ticket and stop. The consequential button belongs to the person who answers for it.

03

Show your sources.

Answer in the desk's own numbers, name what you read and when, and link every line back to where it lives.

04

Stay interruptible.

Show the work in plain steps, stop the moment you're asked, and say exactly what failed.

Rick Hollandsworth
Principal Product Designer · FinFront SDK is a self-directed prototype; all data is synthetic.

rick.hollandsworth@outlook.com
(201) 404-5031
Want the full walkthrough? Message me.

FinFront SDK is a self-directed prototype built for portfolio demonstration — not a licensed product. All data shown is synthetic.